

Quit Doling Out That Bad-Economy Line

IN THE LAST chapter, we examined politically tinged market commentaries that were neither objective nor helpful to investors. These commentaries hurt Democrats during the Bush presidency and Republicans when Obama was in the White House.

But to truly show you the damage partisan-motivated commentary can wreak, we need to go to Donald Luskin, the commentator with the world's worst timing. No one is a more reliable ideological contrary indicator than he. His track record as an investment writer is unmatched on either the left or the right. It's not just that his hot takes on the market were so bad—yes, they were awful—but rather, it is his impeccable timing that brings him to our attention.

He is a one-man instruction manual on how *not to allow* your partisan leanings to influence your investment portfolio.

September 14, 2008 was the day the single dumbest column ever published in the *Washington Post* appeared: “Quit Doling Out That Bad-Economy Line,” by Don Luskin.³²² In it, he explained that the economy was great and all the worrying was like “a virus.”

Breathtaking in its ignorance, shocking in its fallibility, astonishing in its author's perversely misperceived worldview, it stands as a monument to the degree of sheer cluelessness any single person could possibly possess:

There have been 11 recessions since the Great Depression. And we're nowhere close to being in the 12th one now. This isn't just a matter of opinion. Words—even words as seemingly subjective as “recession”—have meaning.

—September 14, 2008